Active sensing explains cortical variability and improves visual information

UCLA Stein Eye Institute · UC Berkeley

Declan P. Rowley[2,*], Ryan A. Ressmeyer[1,*], Tejasvi Kothapalli[3,4,*], Alexander C. Huk[2], Jude F. Mitchell[5], Daniel A. Butts[6], Jacob L. Yates[3,4]

[1]Department of Bioengineering, University of Washington; [2]Fuster Laboratory for Cognitive Neuroscience, Departments of Psychiatry & Biobehavioral Sciences and Ophthalmology, UCLA
[3]Redwood Center for Theoretical Neuroscience, UC Berkeley; [4]Herbert Wertheim School of Optometry and Vision Science, UC Berkeley
[5]Brain and Cognitive Science, University of Rochester; [6]Department of Biology, University of Maryland, College Park; *Equal contribution

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What looks like noise may reflect active sensing

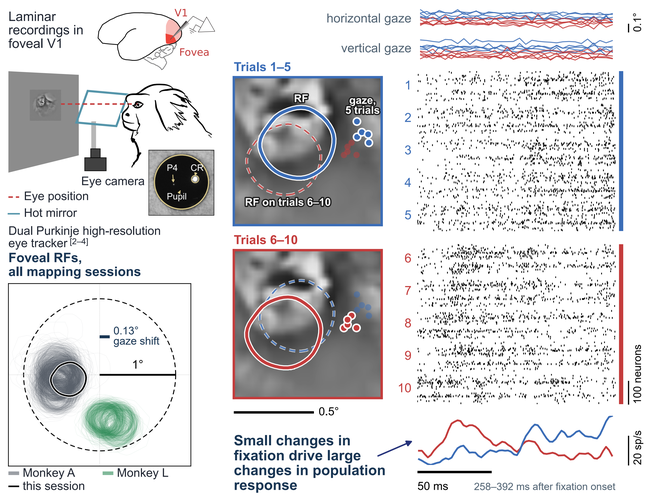
Neurons respond differently across repeated presentations of the same stimulus. These trial-to-trial differences are often described as “noise,” but they can include sensory effects of the animal’s own movements.

Even during fixation, small eye movements continually reshape visual input.

How much cortical variability comes from the eye?

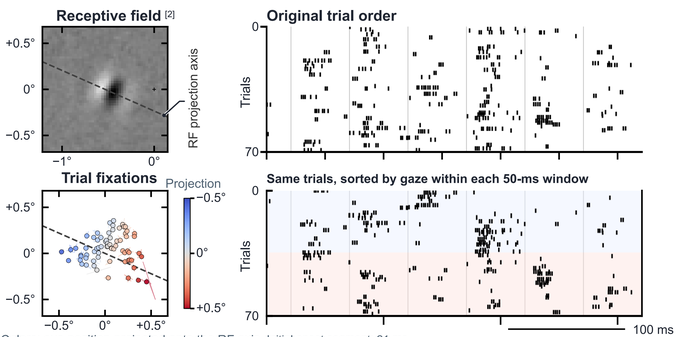
Do fixational eye movements help encode spatial detail?

1 Tiny gaze shifts reshape population responses



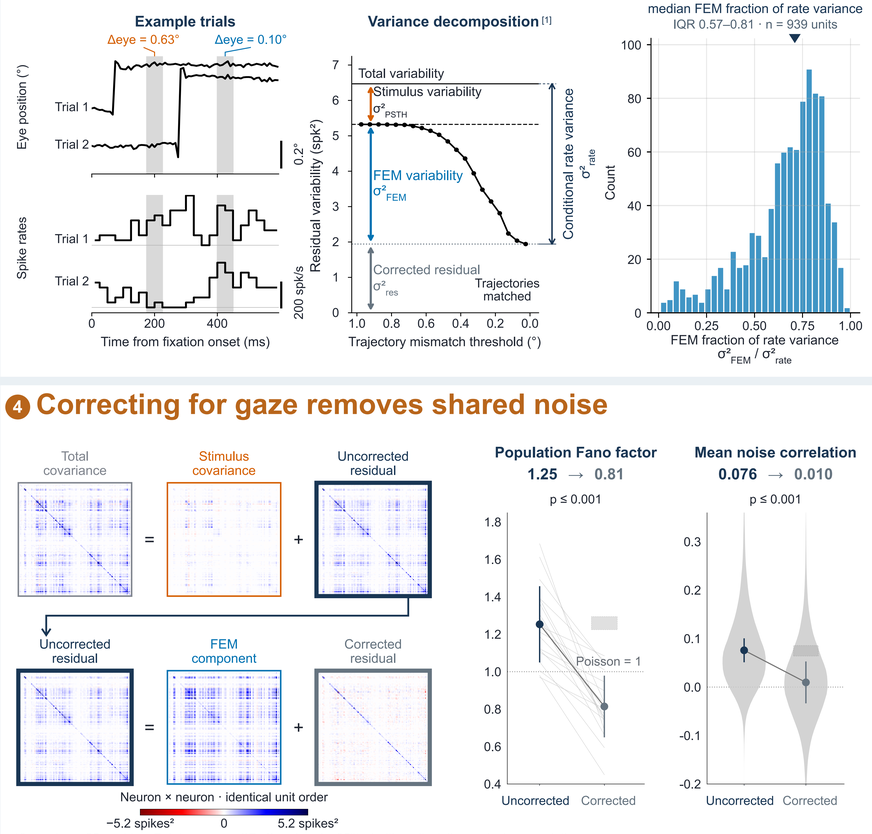
2	1,022	19	20 Hz
awake marmosets	foveal V1 units	recording sessions	repeated natural images

2 One neuron’s “noise” tracks the eye



Colors: eye position projected onto the RF axis. Initial onset segment: 21 ms.

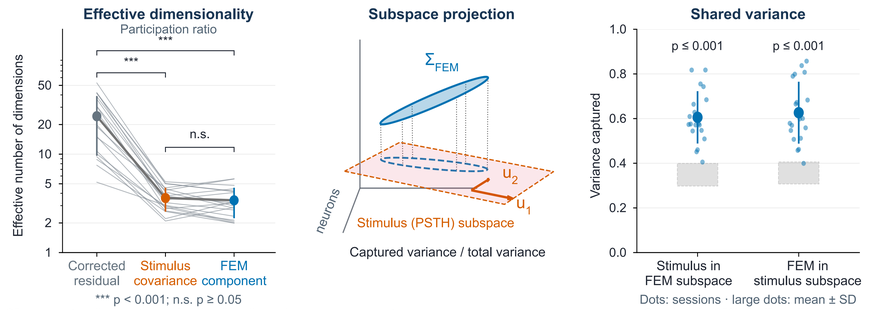
3 Eye movements drive most single-cell rate variance (71%)



4 Correcting for gaze removes shared noise

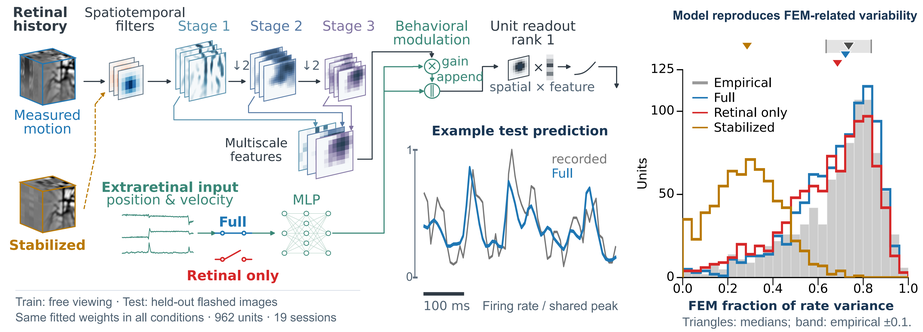
19 sessions; 25-ms bins. Points: mean ± SD. Gray bands: 95% shuffle null; violins: pairwise correlations.
Corrected mean noise correlation: 95% CI −0.010 to 0.029. Both tests compare correction with shuffle.

5 Eye-driven variability follows stimulus dimensions



*** p < 0.001; n.s. p ≥ 0.05
25-ms counts; alignment uses four leading dimensions per component.
Dots: sessions · large dots: mean ± SD
Gray bands: 95% shuffle-null intervals

6 Gaze-dependent retinal input predicts single trials



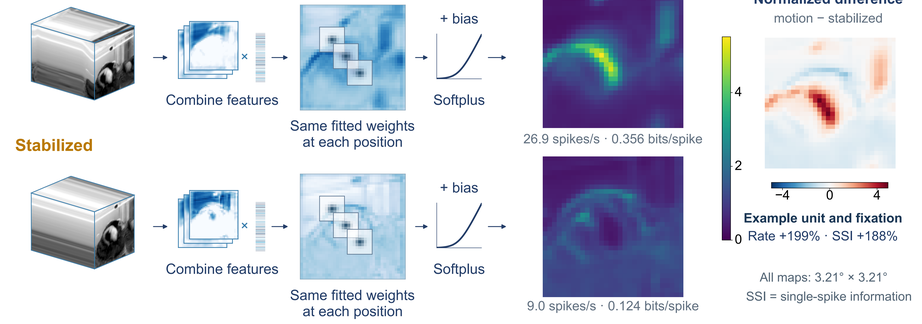
Train: free viewing · Test: held-out flashed images
Same fitted weights in all conditions · 962 units · 19 sessions

Single-trial prediction performance
Median fraction of conditional rate variance explained

Trial average	Full	Retinal only	Stabilized
0.139	0.235	0.226	0.042

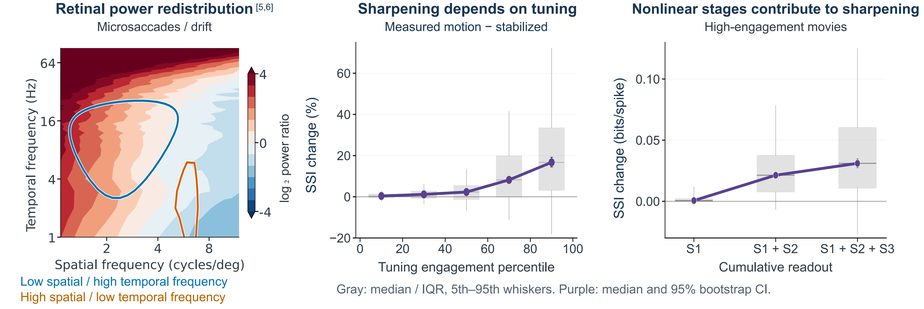
Triangles: medians; band: empirical ±0.1.

7 In the model, eye motion sharpens spatial coding



8 In the model, sharpening increases with tuning engagement

725 units



Tuning engagement: motion-generated retinal power falling within a unit’s tuning; percentiles are within-unit.
All quintiles/stages > 0 (Holm-adjusted p < 0.05).
Gray: median / IQR, 5th–95th whiskers. Purple: median and 95% bootstrap CI.

References
[1] McFarland 2016 · [2] Yates 2023 · [3] Wu 2023
[4] Ressmeyer 2026 · [5] Rucci & Victor 2015 · [6] Kuang 2012

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Contact
Declan P. Rowley · UCLA
declanrowley@g.ucla.edu

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